



## Summary

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Oedipus visits the blind seer Teiresias to find out who killed King Laius, so that he can end the plague that has befallen the city. But Teiresias asks to go home. He does not want to tell Oedipus what he knows. Oedipus begs him to tell him, for the good of the city. Teiresias remains reluctant, which enrages Oedipus. He accuses Teiresias of planning the king's murder. Teiresias fires back that Oedipus is the man whom he seeks. Oedipus is the one who will bring plague upon the land. Oedipus calls Teiresias a slanderer and a liar, and Teiresias replies that although Oedipus has eyes, he does not know his lineage and that the curse upon their land will drive him across the border. Finally, says Teiresias, when Oedipus discovers what he has done, his cries of bitterness and regret will reverberate across the lands. Teiresias predicts that Oedipus will suffer more than other mortals.

## Read

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- 1 *[Enter TEIRESIAS, led by a boy.]*
- 2 OEDIPUS: Teiresias, **seer** who comprehendest all,  
3 Lore of the wise and hidden mysteries,  
4 High things of heaven and low things of the earth  
5 Thou knowest, though thy blinded eyes see naught,  
6 What plague infects our city; and we turn  
7 To thee, O seer, our one defense and shield.  
8 The purport of the answer that the God  
9 Returned to us who sought his oracle,  
10 The messengers have doubtless told thee—how  
11 One course alone could rid us of the pest,  
12 To find the murderers of Laius,  
13 And slay them or expel them from the land.  
14 Therefore begrudging neither **augury**  
15 Nor other divination that is thine,  
16 O save thyself, thy country, and thy king,  
17 Save all from this defilement of blood shed.  
18 On thee we rest. This is man's highest end,  
19 To others' service all his powers to lend.

20 TEIRESIAS: Alas, alas, what misery to be wise  
21 When wisdom profits nothing! This old lore  
22 I had forgotten; else I were not here.

23 OEDIPUS: What ails thee? Why this melancholy mood?

24 TEIRESIAS: Let me go home; prevent me not; 'twere best  
25 That thou shouldst bear thy burden and I mine.

26 OEDIPUS: For shame! no true-born Theban patriot  
27 Would thus withhold the word of prophecy.

28 TEIRESIAS: Thy words, O king, are wide of the mark, and I  
29 For fear lest I too trip like thee...

30 OEDIPUS: Oh speak, Withhold not,  
31 I adjure thee, if thou know'st,  
32 Thy knowledge. We are all thy suppliants.

33 TEIRESIAS: Aye, for ye all are witless, but my voice  
34 Will ne'er reveal my miseries—or thine.

35 OEDIPUS: What then, thou knowest, and yet wilt not speak!  
36 Wouldst thou betray us and destroy the State?

37 TEIRESIAS: I will not vex myself nor thee. Why ask  
38 Thus idly what from me thou shalt not learn?

39 OEDIPUS: Monster! thy silence would incense a flint.  
40 Will nothing loose thy tongue? Can nothing melt thee,  
41 Or shake thy dogged **taciturnity**?

42 TEIRESIAS: Thou blam'st my mood and seest not thine own  
43 Wherewith thou art mated; no, thou taxest me.

44 OEDIPUS: And who could stay his choler when he heard  
45 How insolently thou dost flout the State?

46 TEIRESIAS: Well, it will come what will, though I be mute.

47 OEDIPUS: Since come it must, thy duty is to tell me.

48 TEIRESIAS: I have no more to say; storm as thou wilt,  
49 And give the rein to all thy pent-up rage.

50 OEDIPUS: Yea, I am wroth, and will not stint my words,  
51 But speak my whole mind. Thou methinks thou art he,  
52 Who planned the crime, aye, and performed it too,  
53 All save the assassination; and if thou  
54 Hadst not been blind, I had been sworn to boot  
55 That thou alone didst do the bloody deed.

56 TEIRESIAS: Is it so? Then I charge thee to abide  
57 By thine own proclamation; from this day  
58 Speak not to these or me. Thou art the man,  
59 Thou the accursed polluter of this land.

60 OEDIPUS: Vile slanderer, thou blurtest forth these taunts,  
61 And think'st forsooth as seer to go scot free.

62 TEIRESIAS: Yea, I am free, strong in the strength of truth.

63 OEDIPUS: Who was thy teacher? not methinks thy art.

64 TEIRESIAS: Thou, goading me against my will to speak.

65 OEDIPUS: What speech? repeat it and resolve my doubt.

66 TEIRESIAS: Didst miss my sense wouldst thou goad me on?

67 OEDIPUS: I but half caught thy meaning; say it again.

68 TEIRESIAS: I say thou art the murderer of the man  
69 Whose murderer thou pursuest.

70 OEDIPUS: Thou shalt rue it  
71 Twice to repeat so gross a **calumny**.

72 TEIRESIAS: Must I say more to aggravate thy rage?

73 OEDIPUS: Say all thou wilt; it will be but waste of breath.

74 TEIRESIAS: I say thou livest with thy nearest kin  
75 In infamy, unwitting in thy shame.

76 OEDIPUS: Think'st thou for aye unscathed to wag thy tongue?

77 TEIRESIAS: Yea, if the might of truth can aught prevail.

78 OEDIPUS: With other men, but not with thee, for thou  
79 In ear, wit, eye, in everything art blind.

80 TEIRESIAS: Poor fool to utter gibes at me which all  
81 Here present will cast back on thee ere long.

82 OEDIPUS: Offspring of endless Night, thou hast no power  
83 O'er me or any man who sees the sun.

84 TEIRESIAS: No, for thy weird is not to fall by me.  
85 I leave to Apollo what concerns the god.

86 OEDIPUS: Is this a plot of Creon, or thine own?

87 TEIRESIAS: Not Creon, thou thyself art thine own bane.

88 OEDIPUS: O wealth and empery and skill by skill  
89 Outwitted in the battlefield of life,  
90 What spite and envy follow in your train!  
91 See, for this crown the State conferred on me.  
92 A gift, a thing I sought not, for this crown  
93 The trusty Creon, my familiar friend,  
94 Hath lain in wait to oust me and suborned  
95 This mountebank, this juggling **charlatan**,  
96 This tricky beggar-priest, for gain alone  
97 Keen-eyed, but in his proper art stone-blind.  
98 Say, sirrah, hast thou ever proved thyself  
99 A prophet? When the riddling Sphinx was here  
100 Why hadst thou no deliverance for this folk?  
101 And yet the riddle was not to be solved  
102 By guess-work but required the prophet's art;  
103 Wherein thou wast found lacking; neither birds  
104 Nor sign from heaven helped thee, but / came,

105 The simple Oedipus; /stopped her mouth  
106 By mother wit, untaught of auguries.  
107 This is the man whom thou wouldst undermine,  
108 In hope to reign with Creon in my stead.  
109 Methinks that thou and thine abettor soon  
110 Will rue your plot to drive the scapegoat out.  
111 Thank thy grey hairs that thou hast still to learn  
112 What chastisement such arrogance deserves.

113 CHORUS: To us it seems that both the seer and thou,  
114 O Oedipus, have spoken angry words.  
115 This is no time to wrangle but consult  
116 How best we may fulfill the oracle.

117 TEIRESIAS: King as thou art, free speech at least is mine  
118 To make reply; in this I am thy peer.  
119 I own no lord but Loxias; him I serve  
120 And ne'er can stand enrolled as Creon's man.  
121 Thus then I answer: since thou hast not spared  
122 To twit me with my blindness—thou hast eyes,  
123 Yet see'st not in what misery thou art fallen,  
124 Nor where thou dwellest nor with whom for mate.  
125 Dost know thy lineage? Nay, thou know'st it not,  
126 And all unwitting art a double foe  
127 To thine own kin, the living and the dead;  
128 Aye and the dogging curse of mother and sire  
129 One day shall drive thee, like a two-edged sword,  
130 Beyond our borders, and the eyes that now  
131 See clear shall henceforward endless night.  
132 Ah whither shall thy bitter cry not reach,  
133 What crag in all Cithaeron but shall then  
134 Reverberate thy wail, when thou hast found  
135 With what a hymeneal thou wast borne  
136 Home, but to no fair haven, on the gale!  
137 Aye, and a flood of ills thou guessest not  
138 Shall set thyself and children in one line.  
139 Flout then both Creon and my words, for none  
140 Of mortals shall be stricken worse than thou.

## Annotations

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